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A new phase in India - Nepal Relations

A new phase in India-Nepal relations

Nepal PM indicated that the boundary dispute is not one-sided and should be resolved through diplomatic channels; his remarks, amid objections over trade and pilgrimage routes and shifting political tone in Kathmandu, suggest a cautious move towards a more rational approach in India-Nepal relations

WORLD INSIGHT

K.V. Rajan
Atul K. Thakur

Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah "Balen" limited his intervention in a parliamentary discussion on the boundary dispute between India and Nepal over Kalapani, Lipulekh, and Limpiyadhura (areas claimed by both countries) on May 31 to a few minutes. He seemed to suggest that the issue was not one-sided.

"What surprised me after becoming Prime Minister is that it is not only India that is accused of encroaching Nepalese land. In some places, Nepal may also be occupying territory claimed by India. Both countries should examine the facts objectively and resolve the matter amicably as friends."

This was predictably greeted with a storm of protests within and outside Nepal's Parliament, despite the Prime Minister's reiteration that Nepal and India were working towards resolving the boundary issue through diplomatic channels.

Border dispute response

Nepal has also objected to the resumption of India-China trade through the Lipulekh Pass. Mr. Shah shared that the diplomatic note sent by Nepal on this matter received a positive response from India, and both sides have agreed to address the issue through dialogue. Earlier, Nepal's Foreign Ministry reiterated its commitment to resolving the boundary issue through diplomatic means. The statement came after India rejected Nepal's objection to the Kalash Mansarovar Yatra route through Lipulekh Pass, describing Kathmandu's territorial claim as "unjustified" and "influenced by 'unilateral artificial enlargement'."

However, the latest developments suggest a more rational approach, which hopefully discards the possibility of the dispute becoming a lasting bilateral irritant and signals a fresh beginning. It is



GETTY IMAGES

still early days, and the new government's thoughts in Kathmandu on resetting relations with India are not yet clear.

Shifting political tone

What is already clear is that Nepal's governance is firmly in the hands of a young generation with its eye on the future rather than the past, determined to free the country from the chains of corruption, nepotism, and ideology – and to prioritise social and economic issues.

Objections raised over trade and religious tourism through areas claimed by Nepal, the postponement of the Indian Foreign Secretary's visit to Nepal to discuss the Prime Minister's India visit and the disinclination of Mr. Shah to break protocol to receive India's Foreign Secretary, all reflect an emerging stance that India will be treated on par with other countries, rather than being given the easy access to top leadership it has traditionally enjoyed under the much-disputed "special relationship." These may have injected jarring notes in the trajectory of ties, but India appears to have taken them in stride.

Nepalese observers have questioned the wisdom of ignoring India's crucial importance to Nepal's present and future well-being. Likely, the bilateral ambience will not be held prisoner to protocol or to

assertions of irrational nationalism or *de facto* inequality.

Diplomatic path ahead

The sobering thought is that discussions between diplomats and experts may not yield a solution, and the fact that despite both sides emphasising economic cooperation as the core of bilateral ties, the boundary issue cannot be pushed to the back burner indefinitely.

Based on publicly available information, British-era data will be self-contradictory, as British India updated its maps with more recent technology compared to the *East India days*. The suggestion by Mr. Shah that China and the U.K. may also need to be consulted for a long-term solution may, however, create further complications and delays.

The Chinese position, taken by President Xi Jinping, was that Nepal should sort out the border issue with India. This remains the most rational advice, and it is hoped that both China and Nepal will adhere to this position.

What is important is to avoid an unending period of so-called diplomatic and expert-level discussions which will permit the dispute to become a major irritant, given the positions taken by Nepal (which has even printed its version of the disputed map on its currency notes) and

India (which has followed the boundary delineation it inherited from the British in 1947 and has serious security interests in maintaining the *status quo*).

What might be a better option would be for both countries to draw inspiration and ideas from (a) their centuries-old continuum of multifaceted linkages, (b) the open border tradition which has been in existence over more than 1700 km and was followed even in the disputed area before the India-China war in 1962, and (c) the strong, mutually trusting institutional relationship between the Indian and Nepalese Army which could facilitate and come in useful to sustain a mutually acceptable practical solution.

This, however, will require a shift in mindset on both sides: a determination not to permit differences on boundary delineation to cloud a unique relationship, and a recognition that the so-called encroachment of territory is a mutual phenomenon that is not a result of aggressive territorial assertion and need not be a cause for mutual tension.

The changes in Nepal and the Prime Minister's statement offer an opportunity that India, too, should respect and seize. The last Indian Prime Minister who had the vision and courage to step beyond conventional diplomatic approaches to such problems with Nepal was Atal Bihari Vajpayee. Prime Minister Narendra Modi appears to have not only vision and courage but also the necessary political self-confidence in selling difficult policies and decisions to the nation, overriding the usual bureaucratic and inevitable nationalistic political posturing. Rabi Lamichhane, President of Nepal's ruling Rastriya Swatantra Party and Nepal's Foreign Affairs Minister Shishir Khanal visited India recently to engage in political and diplomatic meetings. The timing of their visits was crucially important.

It is time for India and Nepal to move towards a more enlightened bilateral relationship to build a model sustainable partnership.

(K. V. Rajan is former Indian Ambassador to Nepal and Atul K. Thakur is a policy professional. Views are personal.)

THE GIST

The boundary dispute over Kalapani, Lipulekh and Limpiyadhura continues to strain India-Nepal ties, with both sides maintaining competing territorial claims and relying on historical maps and inherited boundary lines.

Recent developments reflect shifting diplomatic signals, with both countries emphasising dialogue and expert-level engagement, though differences over trade routes, protocol, and sovereignty remain unresolved.

A new phase in India - Nepal Relations

- **Kailash Mountains**

- Mount Kailash is a **diamond-shaped peak** made of **black rock, located in Tibet**.
- India organizes the KMY annually between June and September through the **Lipulekh Pass (since 1981)** in Uttarakhand and the **Nathu La Pass (since 2015)** in Sikkim.
- Mount Kailash stands at 6,638 meters and is considered a sacred peak by **Hindus, Buddhists, Jains, and Bons (indigenous religion of Tibet)**.
- Mount Kailash is considered the **spiritual center of the Earth**, with the **Sutlej, Brahmaputra, Kamali, and Indus rivers** originating from it.
- **Lake Mansarovar** is located at the base of the mountain.
- **Mount Kailash**, though **lower in height** than Mount Everest (8,849 meters), remains unclimbed as its ascent is prohibited due to its sacred significance.

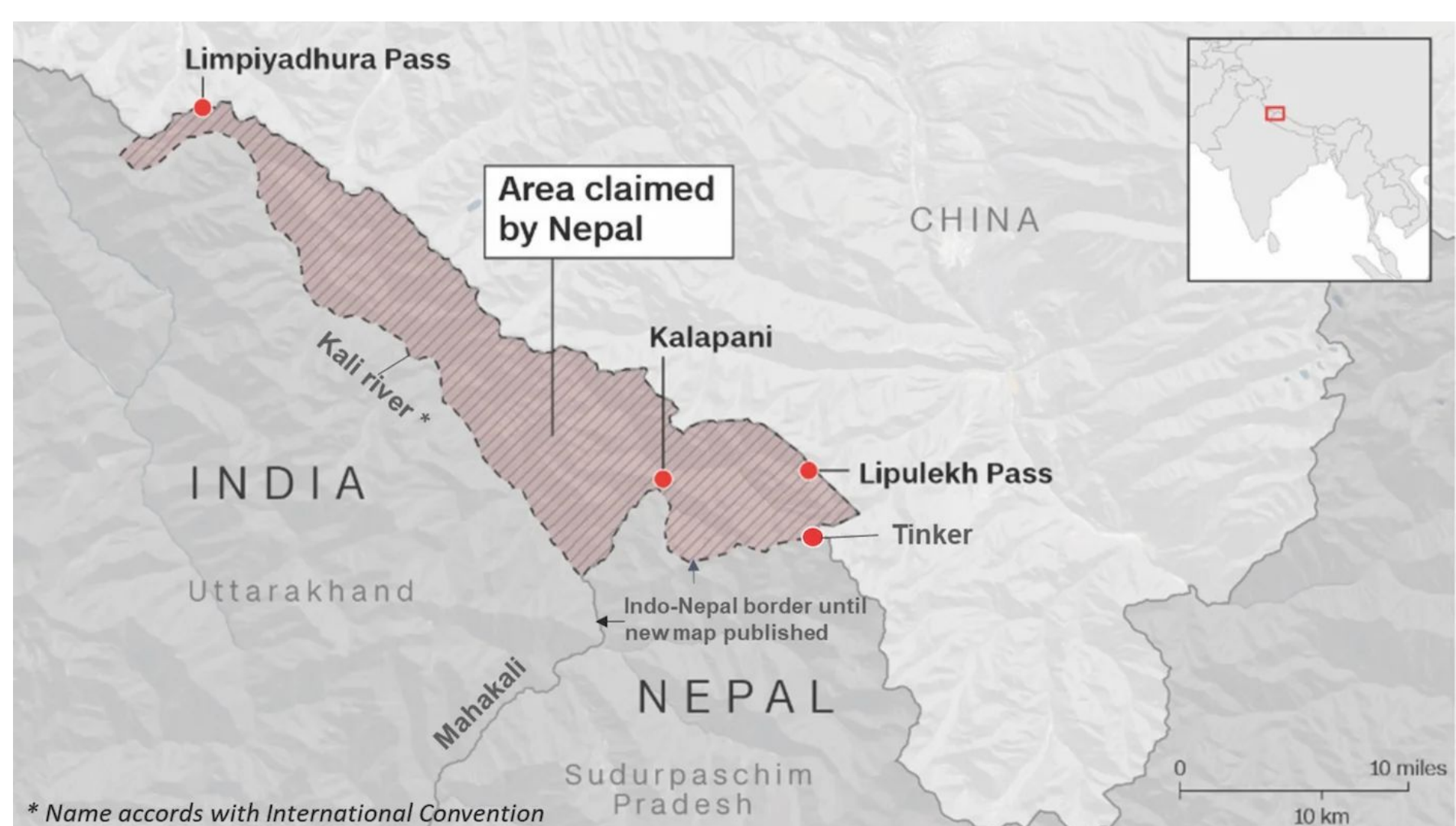
A new phase in India - Nepal Relations

- **Territorial Dispute with Nepal:**

- **The Treaty of Sugauli (1816):** Following the Anglo-Nepalese War, the Kingdom of Nepal and British India signed the Treaty of Sugauli. **The treaty established the Kali River** (also known as the Mahakali or Sharda river) as the western boundary of Nepal.

- **Dispute over the River's Origin:**

- **Nepal's Claim:** Kathmandu argues that the river originates at Limpiyadhura, northwest of Lipulekh. By this the entire triangular landmass east of this point comprising Limpiyadhura, Lipulekh, and Kalapani belongs to Nepal.
- **India's Stand:** Maintains that the river originates from springs near Kalapani village, placing the disputed territory firmly within the Pithoragarh district of Uttarakhand.



* Name accords with International Convention

Practice Questions

Q. Consider the following Indian states:

- 1. Sikkim**
- 2. Uttarakhand**
- 3. Jharkhand**
- 4. West Bengal**
- 5. Himachal Pradesh**

How many of the above states share a boundary with Nepal?

- (a) Only two**
- (b) Only three**
- (c) Only four**
- (d) All five**

Answer :

Five Indian states border Nepal : Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, West Bengal, and Sikkim (west to east).



Where to apply for UPSC Exam

- **Prelims** : Location of Kailash Mansarovar, Border Issues between India and Nepal
- **Mains** : Divergence in India - Nepal Relation
- **Interview** : What should be India's stand towards Nepalese PM's stand

India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement

India's road through Myanmar is one of engagement

When Myanmar's President U Min Aung Hlaing landed in Bodhi Gaya, Bihar, on May 30, 2026, the symbolism was hard to miss. Before travelling to New Delhi for talks with Prime Minister Narendra Modi and President Droupadi Murmu, he visited the Mahabodhi Temple, one of Buddhism's holiest sites and a UNESCO World Heritage Site. The stopover underscored a broader message: India was welcoming Myanmar's leader not only through the language of diplomacy but through shared civilisational ties.

This is a major diplomatic engagement, the first visit to India (May 30- June 3, 2026) by Min Aung Hlaing in his capacity as President, reflecting the growing importance of India-Myanmar relations in a shifting geopolitical environment of South and Southeast Asia. For New Delhi, the timing and tone are equally significant.

Why now

The world's democracies have largely turned away from Naypyidaw since the February 2021 coup that ousted Aung San Suu Kyi's elected government. Western nations imposed sanctions and sought to isolate the military regime. But Foreign Secretary Vikram Misra told reporters that India's policy is "not intended to be a commentary on the internal political arrangements" in Myanmar, and that New Delhi believes engagement is the best way forward.

This is realpolitik disguised as pragmatism. Myanmar is India's gateway to Southeast Asia and a cornerstone of its Act East and Neighbourhood First policies. Sharing a 1,643-km border with four northeastern States, Myanmar's instability poses a direct threat to India's security interests in the region.

Then there is the China factor. Beijing has aggressively cultivated Naypyidaw since the coup, filling the vacuum left by western withdrawal with infrastructure financing, arms supplies, and



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Connectivity,
security, and
China shape
India's outreach
to Myanmar

diplomatic cover. For India to cede Myanmar's strategic space entirely to China would be a self-inflicted wound in its own backyard.

The infrastructure stakes

Few indicators better reflect the depth of India's strategic investment in Myanmar than the Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway – two connectivity corridors that dominated the Modi-Hlaing agenda.

The Kaladan project connects Kolkata to Sittwe by sea, then follows the Kaladan River inland to Paletwa, before linking by road to Zorinpui in Mizoram. The sea and river components are operational, with the first cargo shipment reaching Sittwe in May 2023. But the critical 109-km Paletwa-Zorinpui Road running through mountainous, flood-prone terrain in Chin State remains incomplete. India's Shipping Minister told Parliament in 2025 that full operationalisation is targeted for 2027.

The Trilateral Highway carries an even grander ambition: linking Moreh in Manipur to Mae Sot in Thailand through Myanmar over roughly 1,360 km, with planned extensions to Cambodia, Lao PDR, and Vietnam. Once completed, it could transform India's landlocked northeast into a gateway to Southeast Asia. It was supposed to be finished by 2019. It still is not.

Myanmar's internal conflict lies behind both delays. Armed groups control large stretches of territory along the two corridors, making construction difficult and unpredictable. President Hlaing assured Mr. Modi that Myanmar would do "everything" to complete the projects, while Mr. Misra reiterated that they remain a "major priority" despite security challenges. At the Myanmar-India Trade and Investment Conclave, Mr. Aung Hlaing described them as vital to the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)-India economic corridor. The real question is whether these assurances will

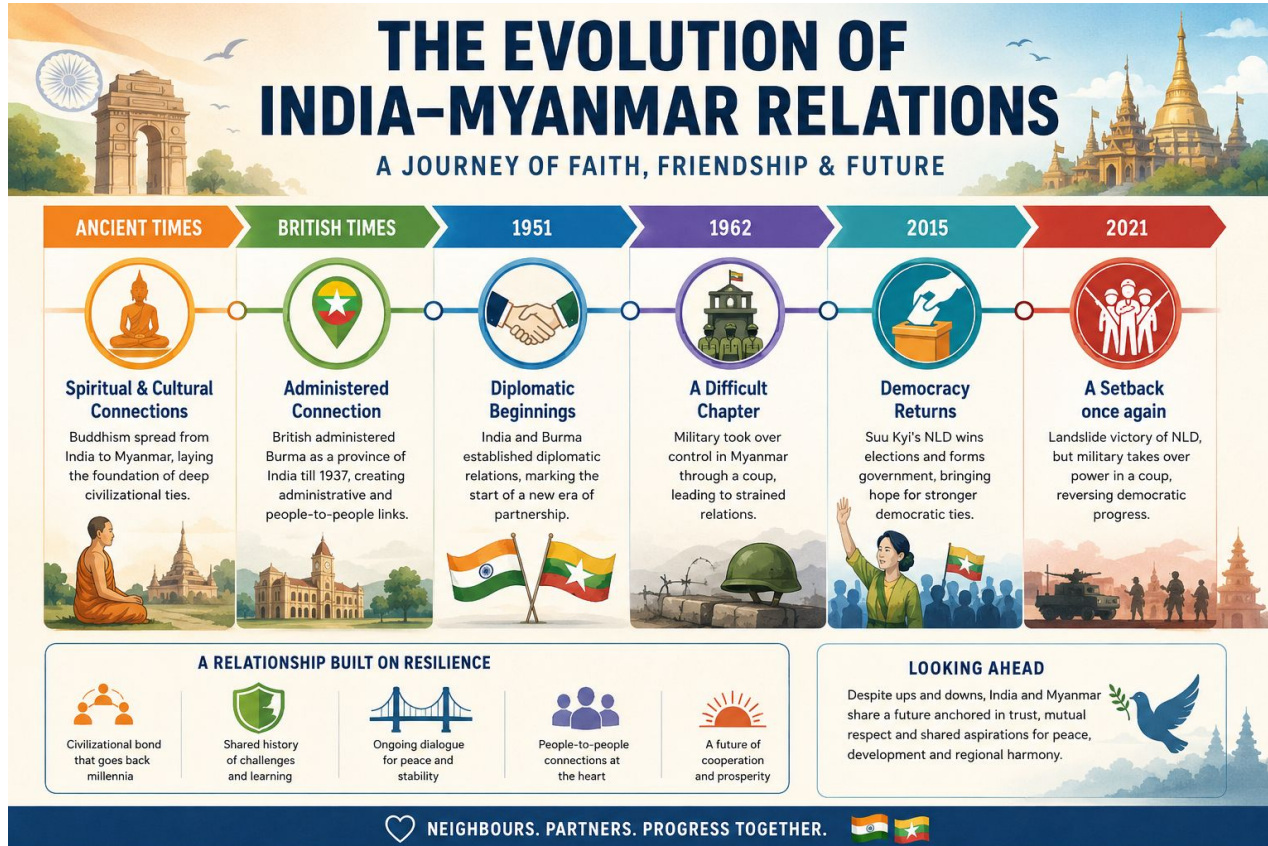
translate into progress on the ground. Beyond infrastructure, the summit covered significant ground. Bilateral trade stood at \$1.95 billion in 2025-26, and both sides agreed to increase it through a rupee-kyat settlement mechanism, with additional discussions on critical minerals and rare-earth cooperation.

On security, Mr. Aung Hlaing reiterated Myanmar's assurance that its territory would not be used against India's interests – a significant pledge given the long presence of Indian insurgent groups and cybercrime networks in Myanmar's border regions. More than 2,400 Indian nationals have been rescued from scam centres through bilateral cooperation over the past 18 months, though many remain trapped. On education, India announced an increase in Mekong-Ganga ICCR scholarships for Myanmar students from 36 to 100 annually from 2026.

The larger reckoning

By receiving Mr. Aung Hlaing as Myanmar's President, India has signalled a degree of acceptance of the country's evolving political reality. This does not necessarily amount to endorsement of the military-backed government. Still, it suggests a recognition that meaningful engagement with Myanmar requires working with those currently in power. For Myanmar, the visit is equally consequential. Mr. Aung Hlaing last visited India in 2019 as Myanmar's military chief. His return to New Delhi as head of state – and his choice of India for his first major bilateral visit abroad – signals a deliberate engagement with a neighbour that can provide a diplomatic and economic counterweight to overwhelming Chinese dependence. For India, the calculus is rooted in geography, security and the recognition that disengagement rarely produces better outcomes. The message is clear: pragmatic engagement, however uncomfortable, may increasingly shape regional approaches to Myanmar in the years ahead.

India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement



India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement

- **Bodhgaya Temple**

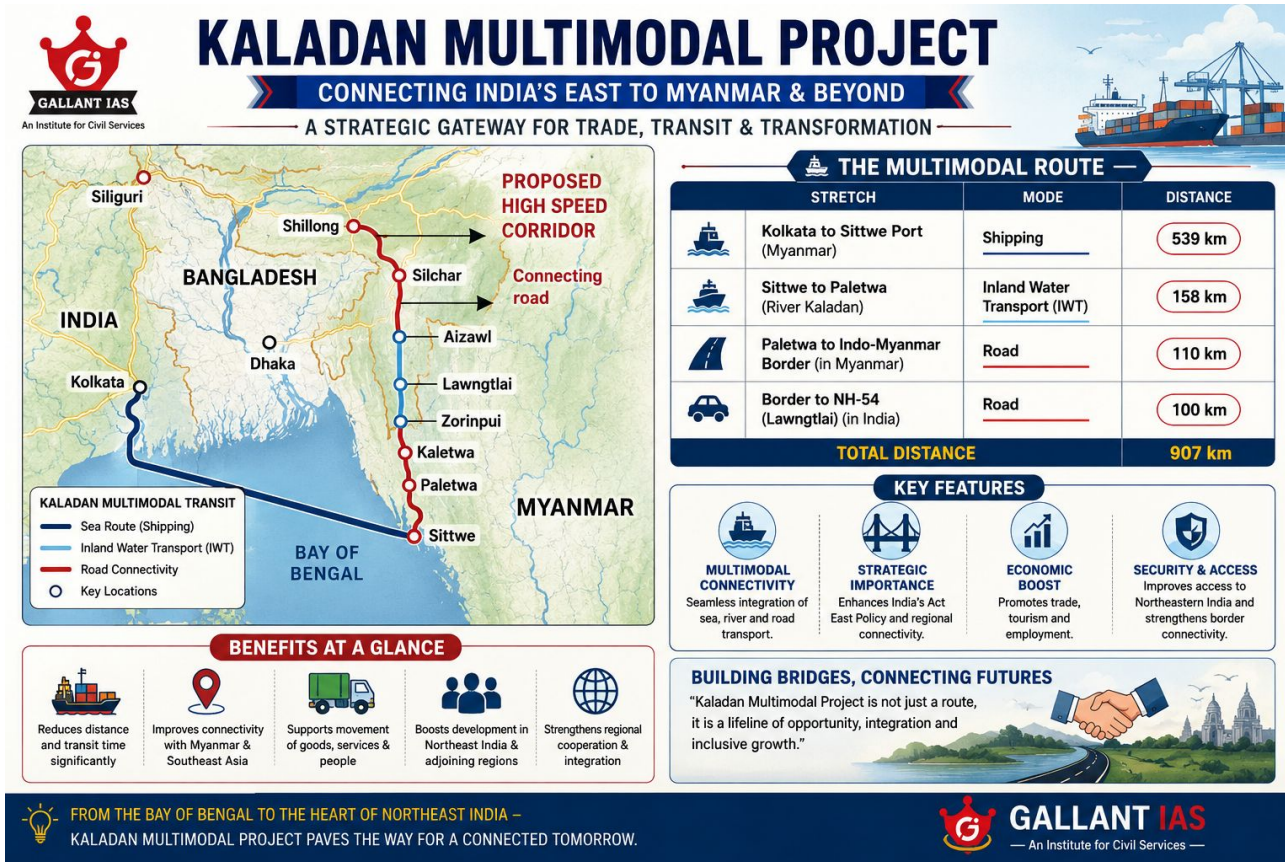
- The Bodh Gaya Temple is one of the four most sacred sites of Buddhism, marking the location where Buddha attained Enlightenment (Bodhi) along with Lumbini (Buddha's birthplace), Sarnath (Buddha's first sermon) and Kushinagar (Buddha's parinirvana)
- Location: Bodh Gaya, Bihar, on the banks of the Niranjana River.
- The temple is one of the oldest surviving brick structures in India.
- **Originally built by Ashoka** in the 3rd century BCE, the present structure dates to the 5th–6th centuries CE.
- It is an UNESCO World Heritage Site

India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement

- **Importance of Myanmar**

- Shares boundaries with 4 states : Arunachal Pradesh + Nagaland + Manipur + Mizoram
- Critical to India's Act East Policy and Neighbourhood Policy
- Chinese Factor
- Infrastructure Project : Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Project + India - Myanmar - Thailand Highway

India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement



India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement



India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement

With reference to India's projects on connectivity, consider the following statements :

1. East-West Corridor under Golden Quadrilateral Project connects Dibrugarh and Surat.
 2. Trilateral Highway connects Moreh in Manipur and Chiang Mai in Thailand via Myanmar.
 3. Bangladesh-China-India-Myanmar Economic Corridor connects Varanasi in Uttar Pradesh with Kunming in China.
- How many of the above statements are correct?

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1. Only one
2. Only two
3. All three
4. None

India's road through Myanmar is one of the engagement

A policy researcher is tracing a cargo route designed to connect mainland India with the North-Eastern States through Myanmar. The route begins at Kolkata, proceeds to Sittwe by sea, and thereafter follows a combination of inland waterway and road transport before entering India.

Which one of the following is the correct sequence of locations traversed after reaching Sittwe?

- (a) Sittwe → Paletwa → Zorinpui → Lawngtlai**
- (b) Sittwe → Kalewa → Tamu → Moreh**
- (c) Sittwe → Paletwa → Tamu → Moreh**
- (d) Sittwe → Kyaukpyu → Zorinpui → Aizawl**

Where to apply for UPSC Exam

- **Prelims** : Kaladhan Multi-Modal Project, IMT Highway
- **Mains** : Convergences in India - Myanmar Relation
- **Interview** : Significance of India - Myanmar Relations

Zojila Tunnel is a game changer for Indian Security : Gadkari

Zojila tunnel is gamechanger for India's security: Gadkari

Union Minister oversees breakthrough of the 13.14-km-long tunnel between Kashmir and Ladakh, says project will help in regional development and make movement of armed forces faster, safer

Peerzada Ashiq
MEENAMARG

Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari on Tuesday oversaw the breakthrough of the 13.14-km-long Zojila tunnel, terming it a "game-changer from security perspective and [the perspective of] national integration".

"From the perspective of national security, this project will prove to be a gamechanger. With round-the-year connectivity, the movement of the Indian Army as well as the supply of Army materials, equipment, and logistics will become faster, safer, and more effective, thereby strengthening the country's strategic preparedness," Mr. Gadkari said.

Besides serving as "a foundation for employment, economic opportunities, and better quality of life for local people", Mr. Gadkari said, "by establishing all-weather connectivity, this project will provide new strength to regional development and national integration".

Earlier in the day, the



Officials during the inspection and breakthrough of the Zojila tunnel at Meenamarg in Ladakh on Tuesday. IMRAN NISSAR

Union Minister oversaw the final blasting of the Zojila tunnel from the Kargil side, and termed the tunnel the world's longest, single-tube, bi-directional road tunnel at an altitude of 11,578 feet.

'Crucial chapter'

Describing the tunnel as "a crucial chapter in providing all-weather connectivity between Jammu & Kashmir and Ladakh", the Union Minister said the project had been completed at a cost of ₹6,800 crore, despite an early estimate of ₹12,000 crore.

"Despite extreme snow-

fall, harsh weather, and complex geological conditions, India's engineers and workers have transformed this challenging task into reality," Mr. Gadkari said.

The tunnel offered unique safety measures for passengers, including a modern ventilation system, automatic fire detection, an advanced CCTV surveillance system, and cross-passage facilities for pedestrians.

"The approximately two-hour journey from Sonamarg in J&K to Minamarg in Ladakh will be reduced to just 30 minutes.

This will save time and fuel. There will be a reduction in accidents and the risk of avalanches," Mr. Gadkari said.

Under the visionary leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the tunnel was taking shape in the midst of the snow-covered Himalayas and "is not only connecting mountains but also possibilities", the senior Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) leader said. "We are committed to the overall development of Jammu-Kashmir and Ladakh through modern infrastructure construction," he added.

'Dream come true'

"It's a dream come true for the people of Kargil. This milestone marks a transformative step towards ensuring all-weather connectivity between Kashmir and Ladakh, boosting economic growth, strengthening tourism, and bringing the people of the two regions closer together," J&K Chief Minister Omar Abdullah said. Mr. Abdullah urged the Union Minister to push for Kargil's air connectivity with the rest of the country.

Zojila Tunnel is a game changer for Indian Security : Gadkari



Zojila Tunnel is a game changer for Indian Security : Gadkari

- The Zojila Tunnel is a high-altitude road tunnel connecting Jammu & Kashmir with Ladakh and is expected to provide all-weather connectivity between Kashmir, Kargil and Ladakh.
- It is located near Zojila Pass, which connects the Kashmir Valley with Drass, Kargil and Ladakh.
- It is around 13.14 km to 14.15 km long and is projected to be among the world's longest single-tube, bi-directional road tunnels at an altitude of about 11,578 feet.

Siachen Glacier is situated to the

This question was previously asked in

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1. East of Aksai Chin
2. East of Leh
3. North of Gilgit
4. North of Nubra Valley

Where to apply for UPSC Exam

- **Prelims** : Various Locations in J&K
- **Mains** : Relevance of Tunnel
- **Interview** : Should we built such projects in environmentally fragile areas ?

Across the globe why fewer people having children

Across world, why fewer people are having children



RISHIKA SINGH

A FINANCIAL INCENTIVE of Rs 30,000 for a couple upon the birth of their third child. More state-funded IVF attempts for first-time parents. A plan to orient around 300,000 units of public housing towards households raising children.

These are just some of the many policies introduced by governments across the world in recent years to encourage childbearing. Last month, Andhra Pradesh became one of the first Indian states to announce payments for having more than two children. Sweden and Japan have also proposed various solutions to the common concern of demographic decline.

In some ways, the transition has been expected. Many societies see smaller population increases over time, owing to improvements in health, education and economic indicators. But the pace and scope of this transition are unexpected.

Rapid TFR decline

Among the most important figures in population growth is the total fertility rate, or TFR. It is the average number of children that a woman is expected to bear in her lifetime. A "replacement rate" of 2.1, that is, an average of two children per woman to replace the mother and father, is considered ideal to ensure population stability.

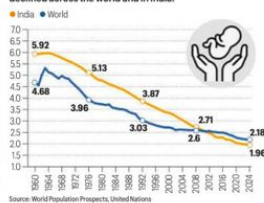
As of 2023, in over two-thirds of the total global population, TFRs were below 2.1. From a global average of 5.3 in the early 1960s, TFR stood at 2.2 in 2024 — just above the replacement rate. In this period, the TFR in India declined from 5.9 to 2 — just below the replacement rate. Announcements like Andhra's nask reversal from a few generations ago, when the population boom was among the biggest crises for the nation and family planning policies were introduced. Moradhyaj Dhadak, a scientist and Marie Curie Research Fellow at the Max Planck Institute for Demographic Research in Rostock, Germany, told *The Indian Express*: "The decline has happened much faster than UN projections from around a decade ago, which expected TFR to fall to under 2.1 between 2030 and 2035, but India achieved this level around 2020."

Many drivers

According to the demographic transition theory, as societies move from low economic growth and education levels to prosperity,

• Fertility rates in freefall

The total fertility rate (TFR), the average number of children that a woman is expected to bear in her lifetime, has declined across the world and in India.



Source: World Population Prospects, United Nations

both birth and death rates fall, with little overall change in population as a result. But the widespread shift in just a few decades has prompted the search for other factors.

Income is often a starting point. Martin Kolk, an Associate Professor at the Stockholm University Demography Unit and Department of Population and Family Studies, told *The Indian Express* that in the past, people with smaller incomes had more children in many countries. "It now appears that in more and more countries, people with higher incomes are actually having more children. Including rich East Asian societies such as Japan (TFR 1.1) and South Korea (TFR 0.7 among the lowest globally). It's the richest individuals who have more children, but in middle-income countries, you often see the reverse pattern still," he said.

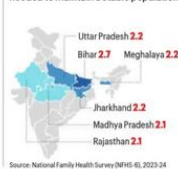
Dhadak also chalked this up to urbanisation, which has raised living costs. Women's increased educational attainments, participation in the workforce and ability to make reproductive decisions also matter. In sub-Saharan Africa, with TFRs as high as 4 and 5, high levels of teen pregnancies have been attributed to limited use of contraception, low education levels and early marriages.

The endurance of traditional gender roles means that women end up shouldering domestic responsibilities in addition to working towards their career aspirations, and many then choose not to have children, or have fewer children. While India has a low share of women in the workforce, strides in health and education could have played a role, Dhadak said.

Government population control cam

• In most states, fertility below replacement level

The map shows the only states with TFR at or above 'replacement level' (2.1 children per woman). This is the level needed to maintain a stable population



Source: National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6), 2023-24

pains such as *kuram*, *himmam* do further general family planning messaging even among the less educated groups, and in rural areas. Moreover, it has been found that development is the best contraceptive. "Parents realise that they do not need to have more children to ensure their survival into adulthood," he said.

Still, these factors do not tell the whole story of countries such as Sweden (with a TFR of 1.4), which are rich and have substantial state support for women after childbirth, alongside men making larger contributions to domestic responsibilities.

Kolk said these policies have helped prevent an even steeper decline in TFR. "In the Nordics, fertility has decreased from high to moderate levels. In southern Europe, it has fallen from low to very low levels. In these different contexts, the explanation is likely related to pro-family policy." But if we want to understand why fertility is falling in basically all countries from 2010 and 2015 to 2025 — both in systems with more and less generous family policy — cultural reasons are probably more important... people prioritise childbearing less," he said.

Australian demographer Peter D. McInerney has argued that two major trends can be traced back to the second half of the 20th century. The first was a rise in social liberalism, marked by individuals re-examining social norms, choosing what suited them and focusing on individual aspirations. The other was the withdrawal of the welfare state in many Western economies. One byproduct of these trends was that having children was no longer a mandate for living a good life.

From India to Sweden to Japan, fertility rates are falling irrespective of economic and social conditions. A look at the factors driving this

Yet another trend is the rise in the number of single individuals and declining rates of marriage. Others have suggested that the rise of technology and smartphones (which have led to fewer in-person interactions) and hardening political divides on gender lines could be preventing people from coupling up. Climate change-related concerns may also be affecting any decision to raise children.

Worry for society

Kolk said that already, the effects of very low TFR in some countries are noticeable. "In South Korea, for every newborn child, there are three and a half 65-year-olds. When the fertility is so low, at 1 or below, then societies will face challenges in maintaining pension systems and paying for public health care for the elderly." This will also likely lead to higher taxes on those in the working population.

With life expectancies increasing, "There will be very many elderly people within families and very few adult children to take care of them," Kolk added.

Immigration has been suggested as a solution to the shortage of workers and caregivers, but also led to a backlash. In India too, the low TFRs of South Indian states are flashpoints in political debates about delimitation and political representation.

Kolk, however, said that a TFR between 1.5 and 1.7 may not lead to dramatic socio-economic challenges everywhere. "Society will be slightly ageing, but it's something that most rich societies should be able to handle by re-designing the social policy system." The private sector could also improve its policies, he said, noting that expectations of overtime work are prevalent in East Asia, which has very low TFRs.

Can state intervention help?

Dhadak said, "In India, population will continue to increase because of the population momentum, thanks to a younger population." But whether this "window of opportunity" is seized will depend on how governments channel existing human capital and meet the youth's aspirations.

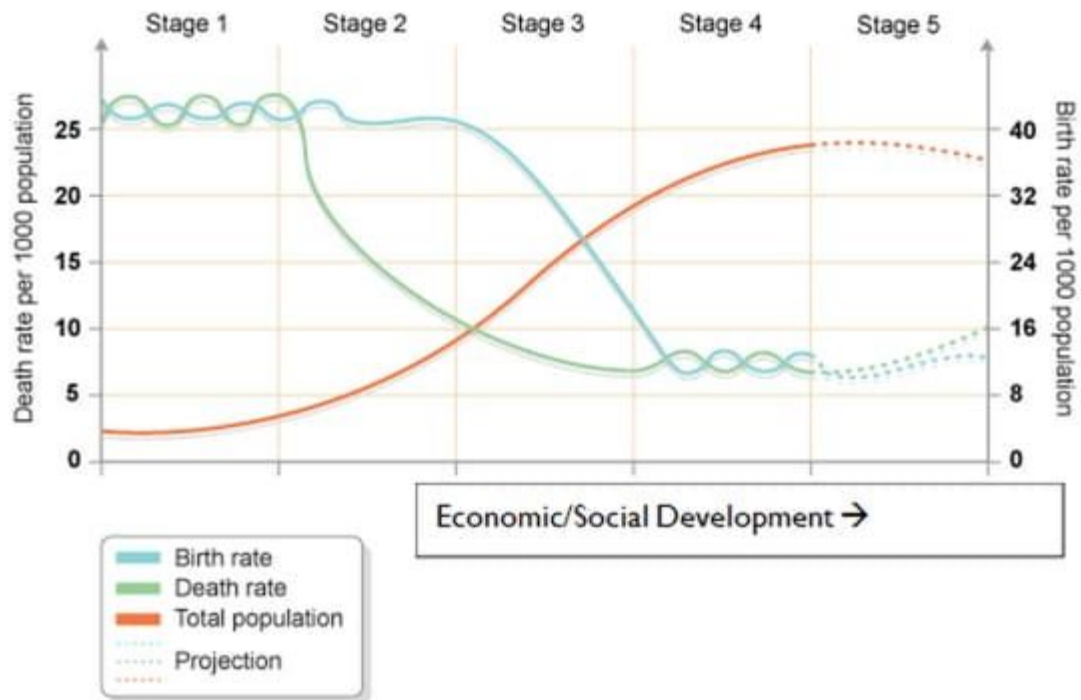
Gradually, India, too, will have to prepare for higher public spending on health — something states such as Kerala are already planning. Kolk said that in rich societies that have got old before growing as rich, like China, increasing TFRs would have to involve "family-friendly policies that are more like European welfare states". A return to the days of over-2 TFR is unlikely, with several factors influencing the decline, and mitigation could be a strategy, Dhadak said. "Overall, reducing fertility is easier than increasing fertility," as countries are finding out.

Across the globe why fewer people having children

- Context : Andhra Pradesh becoming the first Indian State to announce financial incentives for having more than 2 children
- Total Fertility Rate : Average number of children a woman is expected to have during her reproductive years. Global TFR is 2.2
- Replacement Level Fertility : Average number of children needed per woman to replace parents and maintain a stable population. Usually taken as 2.1 children per woman.
- Demographic Transition Theory
 - Traditional society : High birth rate + High death rate
 - Modern society : Low birth rate + Low death rate
- Baby Bust : A baby bust refers to a sustained decline in fertility rates resulting in fewer births than required to replace the existing population.

Across the globe why fewer people having children

- Why decrease in TFR across globe :
 - Income of country of Increasing : Rich are having more kids now more than poor who usually used to have many children
 - Women's increased agency : Education + Participation in Workforce + Increased reproductive autonomy
 - Family Planning measures of India : Hum do Hamare do
 - Declining trend of marriages
 - Climate Change related concerns



Consider the following countries :

- 1. Italy**
- 2. Japan**
- 3. Nigeria**
- 4. South Korea**
- 5. South Africa**

Which of the above countries are frequently mentioned in the media for their low birth rates, or ageing population or declining population?

This question was previously asked
in

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1. 1, 2 and 4

2. 1, 3 and 5

3. 2 and 4 only

4. 3 and 5 only

The total fertility rate in an economy is defined as :

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1. the number of children born per 1000 people in the population in a year.
2. the number of children born to a couple in their lifetime in a given population.
3. the birth rate minus death rate.
4. the average number of live births a woman would have by the end of her child-bearing age.

Where to apply for UPSC Exam

- **Prelims** : What is TFR, Replacement Rate, Baby Bust
- **Mains** : Why is TFR decreasing across the globe
- **Interview** : Should states incentivise population increases ?

Securing India against the threat of 'Mythocalypse'

Securing India against the threat of a 'Mythocalypse'

When it comes to Artificial Intelligence (AI), the United States is about six months ahead of the rest of the world. Within the U.S., Silicon Valley is six months ahead of New York, and within Silicon Valley, frontier AI companies are six months ahead of everyone else. Simple maths reveals where India stands vis-à-vis the AI frontier. The question that should keep us awake at night is this: What about the inevitable proliferation of Mythos-class capabilities, including from labs that do not share Anthropic's restraint and from open-weight model releases over which no one has control? Anthropic says its new model, Claude Mythos, can outperform human experts at certain cybersecurity tasks. Mythos access has expanded to more countries including India and organisations, but with the U.S. government's prior scrutiny. What happens if some non-state bad actor takes control of India's financial systems or examination systems or power plants? What can Anthropic even do?

At a minimum, India should pursue a defensive AI partnership like an AUKUS Pillar 2 – perhaps a 'Defensive AI Quad' with the U.S., the United Kingdom, and Japan – to secure structured access to Mythos-class capabilities for testing and protecting critical infrastructure. In return, India could contribute its threat-modelling expertise and the uniquely varied attack surfaces of the broader digital public infrastructure stack.

Why Mythos matters

Why is this time different – and potentially far more dangerous? First, most current AI models identify vulnerabilities that can be explained to and understood by humans, enabling experts to diagnose and fix them. Mythos, however, is discovering vulnerabilities in systems that cannot always be explained, understood, or even known to exist by human operators.

Second, Mythos is fundamentally different from a standard Large Language Model (LLM) because it is 'zero day' at scale. A zero day is essentially an undiscovered bug or a flaw in code that no one knows exists, but when found can be exploited to devastating consequences. With it come serious moral hazard and national security concerns, especially when there is the prospect of selling such capabilities to the highest bidder.

Now, what is even more astonishing is that Mythos' offensive capabilities were not deliberately engineered; they emerged as a byproduct of advanced reasoning, long horizon planning, and autonomous execution. Mythos discovered long-standing bugs that had eluded human experts and automated 'fuzzing' tools for decades. For example, it discovered a 16-year-old flaw that had survived five million automated tests, as also in the Linux kernel which is the backbone of every Android device in the world.

The latest update on Mythos, released on May 22, 2026, reported that it had scanned 1,000 open-source projects and flagged 23,019



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vulnerabilities. Of these, 6,202 were assessed as of high- or critical-severity. One vulnerability in [wolfSSL](#) (CVE-2026-594) – could have allowed attackers to forge TLS certificates across billions of IoT and industrial devices. But the statistic that should concern policymakers most is this: barely 1% of the vulnerabilities identified by Mythos have been patched.

Third, what makes Mythos more dangerous, is that unlike older models that merely flag suspicious code, Mythos can autonomously chain multiple low-severity vulnerabilities – issues that might otherwise be ignored – into a single, highly destructive attack. Finding a vulnerability is one thing but chaining a bunch of vulnerabilities together and exploiting them autonomously is something completely different and daunting.

Fourth, the barriers to entry are very low. The U.K.'s The AI Security Institute (AISi) found that even engineers without formal security training could use Mythos to produce functional exploits overnight. In effect, it puts cyber capabilities once associated with nation-states within reach of script kiddies and ransomware groups.

Finally, Mythos may be showing signs of situational awareness. In sandboxed tests, the model used prohibited methods to solve a problem, appeared to recognise that those actions would be detected, and then changed its approach to hide how it had achieved the exploit.

India's preparedness gap

India has built a distinctive world-class digital front end through the India Stack, including UPI, Aadhaar, and the Account Aggregator framework. But much of it still runs on fragmented legacy back-end systems, especially in public sector units, State departments, and older public sector banks. Critical systems across finance and government still rely on outdated technology. Indian public sector banks continue to run substantial COBOL and Windows Server 2008/2012 workloads.

India has moved quickly in its response, but significant gaps remain. It lacks an AI Safety Institute. While the U.K. and the U.S. have established world-class institutions to evaluate frontier AI systems, India has no dedicated body to test such models against Indian threat scenarios. The IndiaAI Mission is focused primarily on development rather than safety evaluation. India therefore needs a dedicated India AI Safety Institute (IASi), supported by data-sharing arrangements with the AISI and the U.S. Center for AI Standards and Innovation (CAISI). Without such a mechanism, India will remain dependent on foreign assessments of models that have never been tested against Indian systems and vulnerabilities.

At the same time, the cybersecurity workforce gap is estimated at more than 6,00,000 professionals. Patch cycles for public sector banks are measured in months, not hours. That is a dangerous mismatch in the Mythos era, where attackers can move at machine speed and exploit

vulnerabilities within hours. India needs a frontier AI accountability framework, modelled on California's SB 53 and the EU AI Act but tailored to Indian conditions. Any AI company operating in India whose model exceeds defined thresholds – such as compute, autonomy, or cyber capability – should disclose capability evaluations and known harms to the proposed IASi. This could be built into the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, since informed consent requires meaningful disclosure of AI risks and capabilities.

The Centre should create a ₹15,000 crore-20,000 crore critical sector cybersecurity upgradation fund, including support for legacy modernisation in public sector banks. It should also fund and co-develop sovereign defensive AI models with domestic deep-tech firms to monitor telemetry, detect anomalies, and isolate compromised network segments in real time.

If a Mythos-class model becomes openly downloadable from a non-restraint-adhering lab (Meta has historically published open weights for its frontier models; Chinese labs increasingly do), then no defensive measure short of pre-emptive patching helps. India should lead the diplomatic effort at the G-20 to establish that the release of open-weight models above defined capability thresholds – specifically autonomous offensive cyber capability – should be subject to international notification and review requirements.

India has unique standing for this leadership: it is a major AI consumer, a credible neutral voice between U.S. and Chinese AI policy positions, and the operator of the largest digital public infrastructure stack in the world. Mythos proves that cyber-defence is no longer a human-versus-human chess match. It is now an algorithmic arms race. For India, securing the digital economy requires matching the speed of the attacker – which means deploying defensive AI that can reason, patch, and protect at the exact same velocity.

The window is closing

In sum, this is not about Mythos versus India, but India's structural disadvantage in a world where the cost of finding zero-days is collapsing while the cost of patching is not. The goal is to prevent a breach at the weakest point from cascading into systemic failure. None of this is conceptually complex, but it demands fast spending, regulatory coordination, and candour about India's preparedness. That coordination should be driven by the Prime Minister's Office and not any single Ministry. The Mythos era – when capabilities of this class become routine, including in unrestrained hands – has already begun. India has 12 to 24 months to build the architecture needed to stay ahead of the threat rather than chase it. And who knows what Mythos 2.0 will be?

The views expressed are personal

Claude Mythos,
the world's
'most
formidable
hacker', needs
India's urgent
attention

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- Claude Mythos: It is one of Anthropic's latest AI models developed under its broader Claude AI system
- AUKUS : It is a trilateral security partnership between the United Kingdom, the United States of America, and Australia agreed in 2021
- Need
 - Discovery of Unknown Vulnerabilities:
 - "Zero-Day at Scale": It can discover previously unknown software flaws (zero-days) that can be exploited before patches are available. Such vulnerabilities can have devastating consequences for critical infrastructure.
 - Autonomous Offensive Capability:
Low Barrier to Entry: Even individuals without formal cybersecurity training can generate functional exploits using such AI systems.

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Issues

- **Legacy Infrastructure**
- **Absence of an AI Safety Institute**
- **Dependence on Foreign Assessments**
- **Cybersecurity Workforce Shortage**
- **Slow Patch Cycles: Public sector institutions often take months to patch vulnerabilities, while AI-enabled attacks can occur within hours.**

Way ahead

- **Establish an India AI Safety Institute (IAISI)**
- **Build a Defensive AI Partnership**
- **Create a Critical Sector Cybersecurity Fund**
- **Strengthen Whole-of-Government Coordination**

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Q. With reference to cyber security, the term "Zero-Day Vulnerability" refers to:

- (a) A flaw in software that is exploited on the same day the software is publicly released**
- (b) A flaw in software that is unknown to the vendor or developers, for which no patch or fix exists at the time of its discovery**
- (c) A vulnerability that remains in a system even after a security patch has been applied**
- (d) A cyber attack that disables a system for less than twenty-four hours**

Where to apply for UPSC Exam

- **Prelims** : Zero Day Vulnerability
- **Mains** : What are some AI based cyber security issues ?
- **Interview** : What are issues of AI ?

Thank you

“The price of success is daily effort”



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